ing for contemporary designs, jewellery firms are launching several sub-brands. For instance, Titan serves 3.8 million customers annually through its 985 stores across its four brands—483 under its flagship Tanishq and the rest for luxury brand Zoya, which specialises in diamond jewellery, contemporary jewellery brand Mia by Tanishq, and omnichannel brand that provides modern jewellery CaratLane. Similarly, Reliance has Bella for workwear, Nitara for children, men's collection and wedding collection, including their signature lines such as the Jewels of India and Vivaham.

That said, jewellery remains highly localised, with consumption patterns varying by region. Heavier traditional plain gold jewellery is preferred in the southern states, while lighter weight and studded jewellery are more popular in the northern and western regions. "As a hyperlocal player, we are a Punjabi in Punjab and a Gujarati in Gujarat," says Kalyanaraman, noting that almost 30-40 per cent of their inventory is region-specific. Novel Jewels is working to contemporise traditional designs by bringing regional craftsmanship to the national stage. "Crafts like Nakkashi and Meenakari are traditional, but we are exploring how to modernise them in ways that appeal to consumers across the country," says Kohli. The brand started with an initial assortment of 15,000 curated jewellery pieces with over 5,000 exclusive designs in each of its four stores and plans to add new collections every 45 days.

Fresh collections seem to have become the mainstay of retailers. Tanishq launches 20-25 new collections every year, says Chawla. While most of the designs are sourced from their inhouse designers, to up the design game, they have partnered with marquee designers like Tarun Tahiliani to launch a new wedding collection, RIVAAH, inspired by popular embroideries such as Chikankari, Kashida, Zardosi and studded, which were transformed into jewellery through *karigari* techniques like Rawa, Filigree, Chandak and enamel work.

Top Sellers

SHARE IN TOTAL GOLD JEWELLERY DEMAND

55% BRIDAL

10% FASHION ITEMS

30-35% DAILY WEAR

SHARE IN OVERALL SALES

60-70% BANGLES AND CHAINS

5-15% RINGS AND EARRINGS

15-20% NECKLACES

Source: Motilal Oswal jewellery report

With a new crop of young Indians seeking contemporary designs, jewellery firms are launching sub-brands like Mia and Candere

AURA OF AUTHENTICITY

Over the last couple of years, gold prices have been rising rapidly due to the increased demand, geopolitical uncertainty and inflationary pressures. The average price of 10 grams was Rs 29,289 in FY18, which steadily rose every year before reaching Rs 60,608 in FY24. Gold jewellery, though, attracts a GST of 3 per cent.

With rising prices, the demand for gold tends to decrease as consumers wait for a price correction. "Consumers do not increase their budgets when gold prices rise," says Joyalukkas's George. "They either opt for light jewellery to meet immediate needs or defer their purchases." However, with the reduction of import duties from 15 per cent to 6 per cent in this year's budget, the demand has surged by at least 30 per cent, adds George.

And it is the organised players consumers are increasingly flocking to, given their USP of trust and brand loyalty. "Adulteration in gold is common, but I feel big brands wouldn't risk their reputation by engaging in such practices," says Prerna. Tanishq, for instance, introduced karatmeters in all its stores 25 years ago to address the issue of under-caratage. "Tanishq was the first major player in the market, but it struggled during its first four years as consumers continued to prefer their family jewellers," says veteran adman Ambi Parameswaran. "The company identified the problem of gold adulteration and leveraged this strategy to turn things around, eventually making Tanishq the crown jewel of Titan." Similarly, Kalyan's My Kalyan initiative helps consumers make an informed purchase decision. Its 1,006 'My Kalyan' centres contributed to 15 per cent of domestic revenue and got over 37 per cent of enrolments to its 'Purchase Advance Scheme' during FY24. Jewellery exchange schemes, certificates of authenticity and buyback offers are also helping organised players expand their influence. Omnichannel strategies, too, have become an integral part of the brand proposition. While online platforms are primarily used for discovery, most purchases still happen offline. "We have built a robust tech backbone so that we can even flip our business model if needed," says Kohli. Similarly, Tanishq has four million monthly active users on its website and mobile app. Mia by Tanishq offers home visits with iPads, allowing customers to browse, order deliveries without stepping into a store. Currently, 9-10 per cent of their jewellery business comes from omnichannel.

The future certainly looks bright for the organised jewellery segment. Is it time then to bid goodbye to the neighbourhood goldsmith? ■